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The 1838 Black Metropolis refers to "the free Black community of Philadelphia during the period from about 1835 to 1845." The project emerged from discovering historical census data and business listings that revealed the community's size had been largely hidden from historical narratives.

The destruction of slave labor and the movement to eliminate slavery.

Loss of voting rights, particularly Pennsylvania's 1838 Constitutional Reform that added "white" to voting qualifications, affecting 40,000 free Black people.

Freedom from slavery and efforts to free enslaved people.

A person who escaped slavery.

A business leader and key figure in the 1838 Black Metropolis who influenced the abolition movement.

Church at 6th and Lombard Street, described as the spiritual and political center.

A census of Philadelphia's 1838 free Black population funded by the Pennsylvania Abolition Society.

Spiritual leader who established the African Methodist Episcopal Church.

A term indicating safe physical space for free Black people to build lives.

White mob violence (1834-1843) targeting Black communities, termed riots but actually organized attacks.

A support system helping freedom seekers reach northern sanctuary cities.

The article clarifies that Black Philadelphians were not concentrated solely in the 7th Ward, as W.E.B. Du Bois's work suggested. Before 1854's consolidation, Philadelphia had named wards, not numbered ones. Population data shows significant Black presence in Pine, New Market, and Lombard wards before mob violence displaced residents.

- Historical photograph of 1838 Black Metropolis era —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_d09d86b64e41497cb43b70099ee8bc76~mv2.jpg
- 1840 Philadelphia ward map —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_781774934c0b44aa895e25ff945a0dc9~mv2.png
- Population growth visualization —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_fd7731ced1c84967b700d3827a178e11~mv2.png